

2

AUTOMATION:

“AUTOMATION Solutions... Cut Down Loss Of Time, Consequently IMPROVING PRODUCTIVITY And EFFICIENCY Of OPERATIONS”

➤ Leading logistics businesses in India are banking on automation to ramp up their productivity while reducing operational costs. Paromik Chakraborty of *Electronics For You* speaks with Vivekanand, country manager - India and SAARC, GreyOrange, to understand the appropriate use case of automated solutions

Q. What warehouse challenges can goods-to-person automation address?

A. Big warehouses face crucial business challenges during order fulfillment operations. The main challenge is faced by the employees who need to travel across the large area amidst a pool of goods to reach the items needed and bring these back to the consolidation zone.

The employees lose a whopping 70 per cent time in just walking to collect the goods from the shelves. This is almost five to six work hours lost by each person unproductively each day.

Automation solutions that provide goods-to-person technology cut down loss of time, consequently improving productivity and efficiency of operations. Moreover, manual consolidation has high chances of errors, which can have financial repercussions (like reverse logistics charges, re-shipping charges and the like) as well as pose a risk to brand reliability. These issues can be avoided with intelligent robotic solutions.

Q. How do artificial intelligence (AI)-powered solutions, like Butler, serve the operator?

A. Butler is a robotic platform that enables goods-to-person operation. In a warehouse, the assigned person has to locate items based on an order, place these in the correct consolidation area and consolidate the complete order before it is shipped out. Using this technology, the person does not need to move.

Storage shelves, which are mobile and contain the goods, are brought



Demo of Butler carrying the mobile storage unit

to the picking station to select and consolidate the necessary items in required quantities on-the-spot. Once an order is consolidated, the operator confirms it, and shelves are sent back to where these are optimised in the warehouse. Popular items get placed closer to the picking area.

Q. What are the underlying technologies used for such solutions?

A. Technologies used are an amalgamation of robotics with machine learning and AI. For example, Butler's overall setup consists of the autonomous mobile robot (Butler), a mobile storage unit where goods are kept, an

automated charging unit, a pick-put station and the software platform called GreyMatter.

Besides automating operations, robots follow an intelligent and opportunistic charging technology, that is, whenever they are a little low on charge and have no task assigned for a while, they go to charge themselves automatically. GreyMatter software is based on decision science, acting as the brain of the system.

Q. How much increase in capex can businesses expect to undergo in these kinds of investments?

A. Before looking at capex, for any